Retirement Security Project
at BROOKINGS

Instructions

Thank you for your interest in the Retirement Security Project position at the Brookings Institution! This assignment has three components, and is designed to assess your data skills, writing ability, and capacity to think creatively about policy-relevant research questions.

Please submit your responses as a single PDF document, along with any code files used to generate your results (Stata, R, Python, etc.). Clearly label all figures and tables. If you make assumptions at any stage, please explain them. We will evaluate your submissions based on technical accuracy, data documentation and reproducibility, quality and clarity of writing, presentation of tables/figures, thoughtfulness and originality, and ability to translate technical research into accessible language.

While you are free to use ChatGPT or another large language model for these tasks, if you do, please disclose that and show your work (prompts, etc.), and be prepared to discuss your work if you are invited for an interview. Note that the questions you are asked during the interview may go beyond the scope of the specific items requested below.

Please submit your materials by **Tuesday, March 10, 2026**. We do not expect that you will spend multiple full days working on this, but we want to give you enough time to allow you to fit this into your schedule as is most convenient. We look forward to reviewing your work!

Component 1: CPS Data Exercise

Develop an annual measure of retirement plan access and participation rates among private sector workers aged 20-64 from 2010 through 2024 using the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC).

Provide your results in a clearly formatted figure with labeled axes, an informative title, and a source note. Also include a formatted table showing the retirement plan access rate and the sample size for each year.

Your results should be accompanied by a 1-2 page write-up that includes:

- A description of the sample construction
- The specific questions used to measure retirement plan access and participation, along with the full question wording
- Whether estimates are weighted, and if so, which weights are used and why
- Any documentation regarding how you treated missing/ambiguous responses
- A discussion of the CPS redesign in 2015, and how it might have impacted the measurement and/or interpretation of retirement plan access and participation rates

Component 2: Summary of Research Findings (500 Words)

Write a 500-word summary of the attached research paper aimed at a generally informed reader of the *New York Times* or *Wall Street Journal* who may not be familiar with economists' jargon.

Your summary should:

- Clearly explain the research question
- Describe the data and methods in plain English
- Summarize the main findings
- Discuss the implications of the findings for policy
- Avoid technical language and equations

Component 3: Short Pitch for a Piece on Retirement Security

Prepare a short pitch for an original analytic piece related to retirement security. The topic does not need to be related to the CPS exercise or past Retirement Security Project topics; however, we encourage you to review prior posts on the Brookings website, particularly from the Retirement Security Project, to understand the style, tone, and scope of typical analytic pieces.

You do **not** need to submit a written document for this portion. However, if invited to interview, you should be prepared to:

- Clearly describe your research question
- Explain why it is policy-relevant and timely
- Outline how you would approach answering the research question